The Lighthouses of Merrow Bay

This guide describes the five lighthouses that protect Merrow Bay, a fictional harbour on a rocky northern coast. Each chapter covers one lighthouse: its history, its keepers, and the light it shows at night. The bay was charted in 1791 by Captain Elsbeth Varga, who named it after the merrow, a sea spirit from local folklore. Shipwrecks on the Hollin Reef were common until the first light was lit. Today all five lights are automated, but the keepers' cottages remain open to visitors from April to October. The chapters that follow are arranged from north to south, in the order a ship entering the bay would pass them.

Chapter 1: Hollin Point Light

Hollin Point Light was the first lighthouse in the bay, completed in 1823. It stands 31 metres tall and is built from grey granite quarried at Tarrow Hill. Its light flashes white twice every ten seconds and is visible for 18 nautical miles. The first keeper was Tobias Wren, who kept the light for 42 years and recorded every storm in a leather logbook that is now displayed in the bay museum. During the great gale of 1852 Wren rowed out alone and rescued eleven sailors from the brig Seraphine after it struck the Hollin Reef.

Chapter 2: Cassel Rock Light

Cassel Rock Light sits on a bare island two kilometres offshore. It was built in 1867 after the steamer Lady Ondine sank on the rock with the loss of 63 lives. The tower is painted with red and white horizontal bands so that it can be recognised in daylight. Its light shows a steady red beam. Because the rock is often cut off by heavy seas, keepers were supplied by a basket hauled along a cable from the mainland. The longest recorded isolation lasted 47 days in the winter of 1903, when the keepers survived on salted fish and rainwater.

Chapter 3: Marrowind Lantern

The Marrowind Lantern is the smallest light in the bay, only 9 metres tall. It was built in 1889 from cast iron prefabricated in a foundry at Glasmere and shipped in 214 numbered pieces. It marks the narrow channel into the inner harbour and shows a green light that flashes once every three seconds. The lantern was the first in the region to be converted to electricity, in 1921. Its keeper, Ada Fenwick, was the first woman appointed as a principal keeper on this coast, and she served from 1921 until her retirement in 1950.

Chapter 4: Southreach Light

Southreach Light guards the southern entrance to the bay. Finished in 1902, it is the tallest of the five at 44 metres, and its octagonal tower is made of brick covered in white render. The light uses a rotating first-order Fresnel lens that weighs nearly six tonnes and floats on a bath of mercury so that it turns smoothly. It shows a white flash every fifteen seconds. Southreach also had a fog signal: a compressed-air horn nicknamed the Old Bull, which sounded two long blasts every minute in poor visibility until it was retired in 1987.

Chapter 5: Automation and the Bay Today

All five lighthouses were automated between 1979 and 1994. Hollin Point was the last to lose its keepers, on 30 June 1994. The lights are now monitored remotely from a control room in the town of Saltmere, and solar panels power the Marrowind Lantern and Cassel Rock Light. The Merrow Bay Lighthouse Trust maintains the keepers’ cottages and runs guided walks along the 23-kilometre coastal path that links the four mainland lights. Tickets for the boat trip to Cassel Rock must be booked in advance because landings depend on the tide.